

Pipeline: Download, Setup and User Guide

Last updated October 9, 2026. About a 12 minute read. Beginner level.

Key takeaways

Pipeline is a free, open source leads CRM for one person. It keeps your contacts, follow-ups, conversations, purchases and market research on your own computer, with no cloud account and no subscription.

The Windows app is the easy route. You unzip a folder and double-click Pipeline.exe.

The first time you open it, a Notepad window shows your email and a random password. Log in, click Change password, and choose your own.

Pipeline does not send messages for you. You do the reaching out, and Pipeline remembers who is due a follow-up.

Your data lives in one folder. Copy it somewhere safe every week.

What Pipeline does and does not do

Pipeline is a small leads CRM. You add people you have found or spoken to, log each conversation, and tick off follow-ups as you do them. A contact moves through six statuses: New, Contacted, Replied, In conversation, Converted and Dead.

- **Contacts:** name, where you found them, their handle and profile link, email, which of your businesses or projects they relate to, tags and notes.
- **Follow-ups:** three dated stages per contact. Ticking one done schedules the next two days later. The Follow-ups page lists everything due or overdue.
- **Conversations:** a dated log of every message, comment, email or call, with an optional screenshot.
- **Purchases and check-ins:** log what a contact bought and set a reminder to get in touch after the sale.
- **Reports:** new contacts, messages sent, replies, sales and revenue for any date range, plus revenue by month and leads by platform.
- **Research:** pain themes, competitor ads and keywords for each of your businesses.
- **Import and export:** bring contacts in from a CSV file, or export them all.

Good to know

Pipeline never contacts anyone. It does not send messages, connect to social networks or scrape websites. The optional Claude connector (see below) can add prospects for you to review, but you decide who to contact and you send every message yourself.

Before you start

- A Windows 10 or Windows 11 computer for the Windows app.
- About 200 MB of free space for the app and room for your data.

- The Microsoft WebView2 runtime. It is already on current Windows 11 and most Windows 10 machines. If the window opens blank, see Troubleshooting.
- Python 3.10 or newer, only if you choose to run Pipeline from the source code. The Windows app does not need Python.

Download and start Pipeline

Use the Windows app unless you want to work with the code. It is the same program, already packaged.

Option 1: The Windows app (no Python needed)

1. Download the Pipeline zip file from the project's download page. It is saved to your Downloads folder.
2. Right-click the zip file, choose Extract All, then click Extract. You get a normal folder called Pipeline. Move the whole folder somewhere permanent, for example your Documents folder. Do not pull Pipeline.exe out on its own, it needs the files beside it.
3. Open the folder and double-click Pipeline.exe.
4. The first start takes a few seconds while Pipeline sets up its database. Wait for the window to open.

Windows says it protected your PC

The first time, Windows may show a blue box saying "Windows protected your PC". This happens because the app is not code signed, which is common for free software. Click More info, then click Run anyway. You only do this once.

Option 2: Run it from the source code

1. Install Python 3.10 or newer from python.org. On the first screen of the installer, tick Add Python to PATH.
2. Download the project (the green Code button, then Download ZIP, or use git) and extract it to a folder.
3. Open a terminal in that folder and create a private Python environment: `python -m venv pipelineenv`
4. Switch it on: `pipelineenv\Scripts\activate` (on Mac or Linux: `source pipelineenv/bin/activate`).
5. Install what Pipeline needs: `pip install -r requirements.txt`
6. Copy the settings template: `copy .env.example .env` (on Mac or Linux: `cp .env.example .env`). You can leave every value as it is.
7. Create the database: `python manage.py migrate`
8. Create your login: `python manage.py create_default_user`. It prints a random password. Copy it.
9. Start Pipeline: `python manage.py runserver`
10. Open your browser at `http://127.0.0.1:8000/` and log in.

To open Pipeline in its own window instead of a browser tab, run `python desktop.py` after step 5. Source data is kept in the data folder inside the project.

Port 8000 already in use?

Run `python manage.py runserver 8001` and open `http://127.0.0.1:8001/` instead.

Your first login and password

Pipeline has no built-in password. The first time it starts, it creates your login with a random 16 character password and saves it in a small text file called `first_login.txt`. The Windows app opens that file in Notepad for you.

1. Read the email and password in the Notepad window. The email looks like an address but it is only your user name.
2. Type them into the Pipeline login page and click Log in.
3. Click Change password in the top right. Enter the random password, then choose a new one twice.
4. Pipeline deletes `first_login.txt` for you as soon as the password is changed. If you ever see the file again, delete it.

Version	Where <code>first_login.txt</code> is
Windows app	C:\Users\<you>\Pipeline Data (paste %USERPROFILE%\Pipeline Data into the File Explorer address bar)
Source code	The data folder inside the project folder

Choose a passphrase

Four or five random words, such as tractor lemon river cupboard, is easier to remember than symbols and much harder to guess. Pipeline rejects very short, very common or all number passwords.

Nobody can recover your account for you

Everything is stored on this computer only. There is no email reset. If you forget the password, use the reset steps further down. Your contacts are not touched.

Set up your pipeline: first session checklist

- Change the first password and check that `first_login.txt` is gone.
- Click Add Contact and enter one real person to see how it works.
- Open the contact and click Log Interaction to record a message you sent.
- Look at the Follow-ups page to see the reminder appear.
- Open Reports to see your numbers update.
- Copy your data folder to a USB drive or another safe place (see Backups).

Everyday use

Adding a contact

Click Add Contact. Only the name is needed. The useful extras are the platform you found them on, their profile link, a status, which of your businesses or projects they relate to, tags separated by commas, and a follow-up date. The business is plain text, so type whatever name you use.

Statuses

Status	Meaning
New	You have found them but not yet reached out.
Contacted	You have sent a first message. Logging an interaction moves a New contact here for you.
Replied	They answered.
In conversation	You are talking.
Converted	They became a customer. Logging a purchase sets this for you.
Dead	No interest. Pipeline asks for a reason so you remember why.

Follow-ups

Set a follow-up date on a contact. The contact page shows Follow-up 1, 2 and 3. Tick one when you have done it and Pipeline sets the next date two days ahead. When the third is ticked, the reminder clears. The Follow-ups page lists every follow-up and check-in, oldest first, with a Mark done button.

Logging conversations

On a contact, click Log Interaction. Choose the date, whether you reached out or they did, the channel, and paste in what was said. You can attach a screenshot. Everything appears on the contact's timeline, together with status changes and purchases.

Purchases and check-ins

When someone buys, click Add Purchase on their page and enter the product and amount. Their total revenue updates and their status becomes Converted. To remember a thank-you or a re-offer, edit the contact and fill in Next check-in and the note. It shows on the Follow-ups page when it is due. Amounts are shown in pounds.

Importing and exporting contacts

Click Import CSV and choose a file with a header row. Columns are matched by name, for example name, email, platform, status, business, tags and notes. Anything unrecognized is ignored. Every row is checked the same way as the Add Contact form. Rows with a problem are skipped and the first few problems are listed by row number, so you can fix the file and import again. Export CSV downloads every contact.

Reports

Pick a start and end date. You see new contacts, messages sent, replies, the reply rate, sales and revenue, a revenue by month chart and a chart of leads by platform.

Research

The Research page shows pain themes (what your audience complains about), competitor ads and keywords, grouped by business. A business appears there once research has been saved for it. You can add research by hand in the Admin area, or through the optional Claude connector.

Where to find things

To do this	Go here
See and search contacts	Contacts (home page)
See what is due	Follow-ups
Check your numbers	Reports
Look at market research	Research
Edit search profiles, follow-up message templates, raw data	Admin
Bring contacts in or out	Import CSV, Export CSV (home page)
Change your password	Change password (top right)

Follow-up message templates

In Admin, under Follow up templates, you can save a reusable message for each follow-up stage. The contact page shows the template for the stage you are on.

Every login must be a superuser

The Admin area only lets in staff users. If you add another login in Admin, tick both Staff status and Superuser status and save again. Otherwise it looks like you have been logged out when you click Admin. The first login is set up correctly.

Connect Claude Desktop (optional)

If you use Claude Desktop, Pipeline can connect to it so Claude can look up your contacts, check what is due, and add new prospects for you to review. This is optional. Pipeline works fully without it.

1. Open Pipeline.exe. It adds itself to Claude Desktop's list of connectors automatically.
2. Restart Claude Desktop once.
3. Ask Claude something like: who is due a follow-up this week?

To find prospects, save a search profile first (in Admin, under Search profiles) describing who you want to reach and the phrases that signal them. Claude reads the profile, searches public pages only, checks for duplicates and adds people as New contacts tagged ai-sourced, with a note on why each one fits. You review them and do all the outreach.

Claude can change your data

The connector can add, edit and delete contacts, purchases and research. Deletes ask Claude to confirm first, but keep a recent backup and read what Claude adds before you act on it.

If the connection does not appear, open the Pipeline Data folder and read `claudio_connect.log`. The connector uses the same database as the app, so anything Claude saves shows up in Pipeline.

Email reminders (optional)

Pipeline can email you a list of what is due. It is a command, not a button, so it suits people running from source. In the `.env` file, set `FOLLOWUP_REMINDER_TO` to your address and fill in the `EMAIL_` lines for your mail provider. Then run `python manage.py followup_reminders`. To run it every morning, use Windows Task Scheduler. With no mail settings the reminder is printed in the terminal instead.

Backups and keeping your data safe

Pipeline keeps everything in one folder. Copy that folder to keep a backup.

Version	Your data folder
Windows app	%USERPROFILE%\Pipeline Data
Source code	The data folder inside the project folder

Inside are `db` (your database), `media` (uploaded screenshots) and `secret_key.txt`. Close Pipeline, then copy the whole folder. To restore, close Pipeline and copy it back. Export CSV is a second, readable copy of your contacts.

Pipeline does not back up for you

Copy your data folder to a USB drive or an encrypted cloud folder every week. A copy on the same disk does not help if the computer is lost or fails. Your database holds names, emails and private conversations, so also use a Windows login password, lock the screen when you leave, and consider turning on BitLocker.

If you forget your password

1. Close Pipeline.
2. Double-click `Pipeline-Reset-Password.bat` in the same folder as `Pipeline.exe`, then press any key when it asks.
3. A Notepad window opens with a new random password.
4. Log in, click Change password and choose your own. Pipeline deletes the file.

Your contacts and research are not touched. From source, run `python manage.py create_default_user --reset` instead.

Anyone who can open your files can reset it

The reset works for anyone using your Windows account. That is why the Windows login password and screen lock matter.

Updating to a new version

1. Close Pipeline and make a backup of your data folder.
2. Extract the new zip into a new folder.
3. Open Pipeline.exe from the new folder. It finds your existing data and updates the database itself.
4. When you are happy, delete the old folder. The data folder is separate, so deleting the old program folder does not delete your data.

If you use the Claude connector, opening the new Pipeline.exe points Claude Desktop at the new folder. Restart Claude Desktop afterwards.

Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
The window is blank or white	Install the Microsoft WebView2 runtime from Microsoft, then open Pipeline again.
Windows blocks Pipeline.exe	Click More info, then Run anyway. If the zip was downloaded from the internet, right-click it, choose Properties and tick Unblock before extracting.
The page looks plain with no styling (source code)	Hold Ctrl and press F5 to refresh without the cached page.
Admin sends me to a login page	The login is not a superuser. See the box under Where to find things.
I cannot find first_login.txt	It is deleted when you change your password. If you have not and you lost it, use the reset steps.
Port 8000 is already in use (source code)	Run python manage.py runserver 8001.
Python is not recognized (source code)	Reinstall Python and tick Add Python to PATH, then open a new terminal.
Claude cannot see Pipeline	Open Pipeline.exe once, restart Claude Desktop, and read claud_connect.log in your data folder.
Where is my data?	See the Backups section.
Can I use it on Mac or Linux?	Run it from source in a browser. The packaged app and the automatic Claude connection are for Windows.
Can two people share it?	No. Pipeline is for one owner on one computer.

Use at your own risk

Pipeline is provided as is, with no warranty. It is a tool for keeping notes, not legal or data protection advice. If you store other people's personal details, you are responsible for handling them lawfully and for keeping backups. See LICENSE.txt for the full terms.

Summary

- Pipeline keeps your leads on your own computer, with no account and no cloud.
- Open Pipeline.exe, read the password in Notepad, then change it.
- Add contacts, log conversations, and tick follow-ups as you go.
- Check Reports to see your replies, sales and revenue.
- Copy your data folder somewhere safe every week.
- If you forget the password, run Pipeline-Reset-Password.bat.